

Three candidate typefaces for the Africa–Asia Development Magazine

Each column applies one candidate to the same sample: display headline, section head, subhead, deck, body, caption, figure-note, tabular numerals, country labels, and a dagger-caveat line. Compare the hierarchy, numeral behaviour, and reading colour side by side, then record a choice in `TYPGRAPHY_DECISION.md`.

Candidates: Montserrat · Inter · IBM Plex Sans **Licence:** all three SIL Open Font Licence 1.1 **Palette:** Palette A — Inherited Editorial (unchanged)

CANDIDATE 1

Montserrat

Geometric sans by Julieta Ulanovsky. Nine weights 100–900 plus italics. Google Fonts; SIL OFL 1.1. The user raised this family by name as a modern alternative to Aptos.

DISPLAY · 32 PT / 900

Divergent paths.

HEADLINE H1 · 24 PT / 700

Why Ghana and South Korea diverged after 1960

SUBHEAD H2 · 16 PT / 700

Observed anchors — not a race

SECTION HEAD H3 · 12 PT / 600

Manufacturing value added as a share of GDP

EYEBROW · 8 PT / 700 · TRACKED

EVIDENCE LEDGER · SPREAD 03

DECK · 11 PT / 400

Three dated observations on one shared axis. African and Asian paths vary within their region; the chart does not establish a cause.

BODY · 9.5 PT / 400

In 1960 Ghana and South Korea reported broadly similar GDP per person in constant 2015 US dollars. Sixty years later they sit decades apart. Culture is one of many candidate explanations the registered evidence pack can neither confirm nor rule out.

CAPTION · 8 PT / 500

Ghana (1,101 → 1,970) and South Korea (1,038 → 33,216) rounded to the nearest constant 2015 US dollar.

FIGURE NOTE · 7.5 PT / 400

Note. Manufacturing value added, current-price share of GDP. Data from World Development Indicators (NV.IND.MANF.ZS), by World Bank (2026). SRC-WDI-001.

TABULAR NUMERALS · 14 PT

1,101 · 9,673 · 25,702 · 1960 —
1990 — 2020 · 9.75 % · 25.70 %

● Ghana
■ Botswana
■ Mauritius

◆ South Korea
◆ Malaysia
■ Philippines

CANDIDATE 2

Inter

Humanist sans by Rasmus Andersson, screen-tuned with excellent small-size reading. Variable weight 100–900 plus display cuts. Google Fonts; SIL OFL 1.1. Widely used in editorial and data-journalism contexts.

DISPLAY · 32 PT / 900

Divergent paths.

HEADLINE H1 · 24 PT / 700

Why Ghana and South Korea diverged after 1960

SUBHEAD H2 · 16 PT / 700

Observed anchors — not a race

SECTION HEAD H3 · 12 PT / 600

Manufacturing value added as a share of GDP

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EVIDENCE LEDGER · SPREAD 03

DECK · 11 PT / 400

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CANDIDATE 3

IBM Plex Sans

Open editorial-technical family by Mike Abbink / Bold Monday for IBM. Seven weights 100–700 plus condensed and mono siblings. Google Fonts; SIL OFL 1.1. Strong editorial personality with calm display behaviour.

DISPLAY · 32 PT / 700 (NO 900 IN PLEX)

Divergent paths.

HEADLINE H1 · 24 PT / 700

Why Ghana and South Korea diverged after 1960

SUBHEAD H2 · 16 PT / 700

Observed anchors — not a race

SECTION HEAD H3 · 12 PT / 600

Manufacturing value added as a share of GDP

EYEBROW · 8 PT / 700 · TRACKED

EVIDENCE LEDGER · SPREAD 03

DECK · 11 PT / 400

Three dated observations on one shared axis. African and Asian paths vary within their region; the chart does not establish a cause.

BODY · 9.5 PT / 400

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† 1965 is a five-year proxy for Ghana's 1960 anchor; the figure prints 1965, not 1960.

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MONTSERRAT — STRENGTHS / WATCH-OUTS

- Strengths.** Confident geometric display; nine weights up to Black (900) for dramatic section openers; modern, friendly voice; wide language coverage; already common in modern infographics.
- Needs a slightly lower body size than Inter at the same visual weight — set body at 9.5 pt, not 10 pt.
 - Tabular lining numerals supported but historically narrower; verify alignment in dense tables.
 - Can read as "startup template" if used at only one weight; use Black + Medium contrast to earn editorial feel.

INTER — STRENGTHS / WATCH-OUTS

- Strengths.** Humanist, screen-tuned, excellent at small sizes; variable axis for continuous weight control; a well-trodden choice in data journalism (FT, Pudding, Our World in Data). Numerals are purpose-built for charts.
- Less distinctive display personality than Montserrat Black or Plex 700; may feel neutral on a cover.
 - Pair with a serif display face if the magazine wants more editorial character on openers.
 - Confirm the Display cuts, not only the base family, if used above 32 pt.

IBM PLEX SANS — STRENGTHS / WATCH-OUTS

- Strengths.** Editorial-technical voice; corporate seriousness without stiffness; strong hierarchy at 600/700; condensed and mono siblings available for figure callouts and code-like captions; well tested in long-form editorial PDFs.
- No weight above 700; display headlines rely on size and tracking rather than Black weight.
 - Numerals are high-contrast and clear but visibly "IBM"; may clash with Palette A warmth unless balanced by cream-heavy layouts.
 - Watch spacing on all-caps eyebrows at small sizes.